

US History: The Civil Rights Movement, 1954-1968

Origins: segregation and the road to Brown v. Board

By the early 1950s, many states enforced legal racial segregation under "Jim Crow" laws, separating Black and white Americans in schools, transportation, restaurants, and public facilities. The Supreme Court had upheld this system in 1896 under the doctrine of "separate but equal," but in practice the facilities provided to Black Americans were consistently inferior.

In 1954, the Supreme Court's decision in Brown v. Board of Education declared that racially segregated public schools were inherently unequal and therefore unconstitutional, overturning "separate but equal" in education. The ruling did not immediately desegregate schools — many Southern states resisted for years — but it gave the growing civil rights movement a powerful legal foundation and a sense that change was possible.

That resistance became visible in 1957, when the governor of Arkansas used the National Guard to block nine Black students from entering Little Rock Central High School. President Eisenhower responded by federalizing the Arkansas National Guard and sending in U.S. Army troops to protect the students, marking one of the first times the federal government used force to enforce desegregation.

Direct action: boycotts, sit-ins, and freedom rides

In December 1955, Rosa Parks was arrested in Montgomery, Alabama, for refusing to give up her bus seat to a white passenger. Her arrest sparked the Montgomery Bus Boycott, a mass, sustained boycott of the city's bus system organized in part by a young minister named Martin Luther King Jr. The boycott lasted over a year and ended only after the Supreme Court ruled bus segregation unconstitutional, establishing boycotts as an effective tool of nonviolent protest.

Direct action spread through the following decade. In 1960, four Black college students sat down at a whites-only lunch counter in Greensboro, North Carolina, and refused to leave; the sit-in movement they started quickly spread to dozens of cities, pressuring businesses to desegregate their facilities. In 1961, Freedom Riders — groups of Black and white activists — rode interstate buses into the segregated South to test a Supreme Court ruling banning segregation in interstate travel, facing violent attacks that drew national media attention to the cause.

In 1963, civil rights organizers targeted Birmingham, Alabama, with marches and sit-ins; the city's police response, including fire hoses and police dogs turned on peaceful protesters, including children, shocked much of the country and increased pressure on the federal government to act. Later that year, the March on Washington for Jobs and Freedom brought roughly 250,000 people to the National Mall, where Martin Luther King Jr. delivered his "I Have a Dream" speech.

Legislative victories: 1964-1965

The Civil Rights Act of 1964 outlawed discrimination on the basis of race, color, religion, sex, or national origin, banning segregation in public accommodations like restaurants and hotels and prohibiting discriminatory practices in employment. It was the most sweeping civil rights legislation passed by Congress since Reconstruction and marked a major turning point from protest to law.

Voting rights remained a major barrier, especially in the South, where discriminatory tests and intimidation kept many Black citizens from registering to vote. In 1965, activists organized a series of marches from Selma to Montgomery, Alabama, to demand voting rights; the first march was met with brutal violence from state troopers on the Edmund Pettus Bridge, an event that became known as "Bloody Sunday" and was broadcast into homes across the country.

The Selma marches directly pressured Congress to pass the Voting Rights Act of 1965, which banned literacy tests and other discriminatory voting requirements and authorized federal oversight of voter registration in states with a history of discrimination. Together, the Civil Rights Act and the Voting Rights Act dismantled the legal structure of segregation and disenfranchisement that Jim Crow had built, even though the struggle for full equality continued well beyond 1968.

Reading the movement: primary versus secondary sources

Historians studying the civil rights movement distinguish between primary and secondary sources. A primary source is a firsthand account or original record created during the events themselves: a photograph from the Selma march, a transcript of King's "I Have a Dream" speech, a newspaper article written the day after the Greensboro sit-ins began, or a government document like the text of the Civil Rights Act of 1964.

A secondary source is created afterward by someone analyzing or interpreting primary sources: a history textbook chapter summarizing the Montgomery Bus Boycott, a documentary film made decades later, or a scholarly article assessing the movement's long-term political effects. Secondary sources are valuable for context and analysis, but they are filtered through another author's interpretation.

When researching the movement, historians favor primary sources for understanding what participants actually experienced and said, while relying on secondary sources to connect individual events — Brown v. Board, Montgomery, Little Rock, the sit-ins, the Freedom Rides, Birmingham, the March on Washington, Selma — into the larger causal chain: legal victories inspired direct action, direct action produced dramatic confrontations, and those confrontations built the political pressure that turned into landmark federal law.